Beauty Queens

By Libba Bray

CAST LIST

Narrator
Mary Lou / Miss Nebraska
Adina / Miss New Hampshire
Taylor / Miss Texas
Girl #1
Miss New Mexico
Tiara / Miss Mississippi
Brittani / Miss Alabama
Nicole / Miss Colorado
Miss Montana (no lines)
Petra
Boss
Agent

NARRATOR: This [story] begins with a plane crash. According to the U.S. Department of Unnecessary Statistics, your chances of dying in a plane crash are one in half a million. Whereas your chances of losing your bathing suit bottoms to a strong tide are two to one. So, all in all, it's safer to fly than to go to the beach.

As I said, this [story] begins with a plane crash. But there are survivors. They are all beauty queen contestants. They are all such nice, happy, shining, patriotic girls who happen to have interests in baton twirling, sign language, AIDS prevention in the animal population, feminine firearms, interpretive dance, and sequins.

The flight is on its way to a remote tropical paradise where the girls will compete against one another for the title of Miss Teen Dream. And so our tale begins with a sudden fall from blue skies, with screams and prayers . . .

And a camera crew bravely recording every bit of the turbulence and drama: What a lucky break for their show! Ratings will skyrocket!

Through the windows, they can see the strange, verdant land taking shape, growing bigger as they descend. It's beautiful. They will land safely, no matter the sudden near-vertical descent. They're sure of it. After all, these are can-do girls from a nation built upon dreams. (Chapter 1)

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INTRODUCTION

The fifty contestants in the Miss Teen Dream Pageant thought this was going to be a fun trip to the beach, where they could parade in their state-appropriate costumes and compete in front of the cameras. But sadly, their airplane had another idea, crashing on a desert island and leaving the survivors stranded with little food, little water, and practically no eyeliner. What's a beauty queen to do? Continue to practice for the talent portion of the program - or wrestle snakes to the ground? Welcome to the heart of non-exfoliated darkness.

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MARY LOU: Are you all right?

ADINA: Am I dead? *(Looks up at Mary Lou standing over her as she lies on the ground)* Are *you* dead?

MARY LOU: No. I'm Miss Nebraska, Mary Lou Novak.

ADINA: Adina Greenberg. Miss New Hampshire.

TAYLOR: *(with strong Texas accent).* All right, Miss Teen Dreamers! Yoo-hoo! I'm wigglin' my fingers for y'all's attention. I'm Taylor Rene Krystal Hawkins, and I'm Miss Teen Dream Texas, the state where dreams are bigger and better. I'm a senior at George Walker Bush High School and I hope to pursue a career as a motivational speaker. *(Polite automatic applause from the other girls)*

GIRL #1: I want to pursue a career in the exciting world of weight-management broadcast journalism. And help kids not have cancer and stuff.

TAYLOR: Okay, Miss Teen Dreamers, I know we're all real flustered and everything. But we're alive. *(loud groan from another girl)*

GIRL #1: Oh my gosh! Miss Delaware just died!

MISS NEW MEXICO: My head kinda hurts. *(Girls gasp…half of an airline serving tray is sticking out of Miss New Mexico's forehead, forming a canopy over her eyes.).* What is it? *(She checks to make sure her bra straps aren't showing.)*

TAYLOR: Any of y'all have first-aid training? *(Tiara and Brittani's hands shoot up).* Names?

TIARA: I'm Tiara with an *A*.

BRITTANI: I'm Brittani with an I. I got my Scouting Badge in First Aid.

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TIARA: Ohmigosh, me, too! You're so nice. If it's not me, I hope you win.

BRITTANI: No, I hope YOU win! (Chapter 2)

ADINA: What we need is a team leader.

TAYLOR: *(tosses hair)* Judges ready? Hi, y'all. I am Taylor Rene Krystal Hawkins, Miss Texas. *(standing in perfect three-quarters stance, arms at her sides)* I have been class president three years in a row, homecoming queen, a National Merit Scholar, and a member of the National Honor Society, and I am a proud, card-carrying member of FAF – Femmes and Firearms. When we get rescued and get to Paradise Cove, America's gonna be wantin' to see a pageant. And I do not intend to let them down. So. Starting tomorrow, we'll be back to working on our dance numbers and our walking, talent, swimsuit, and evening gown presentations, just like nothing ever happened. Thank you. *(Roar of applause)*

ADINA: Um, not to be rude or anything, but usually you put it to a vote.

TAYLOR: What are your leadership qualifications?

ADINA: Hello. I am Adina Greenberg, Miss New Hampshire, and I would like to be your team leader. Point A: We need to think realistically. It could be weeks before we're rescued. I submit that our goal should be survival. We need to find food and potable water. I think we should find some kind of shelter; a cave or something.

TIARA: What if there's, like, a creature living in the cave? Seriously, I saw this show once where these people were stranded on an island and there were these people who were sort of crazy-slash-bad and there was this polar bear creature running around.

ADINA: *(Interrupting)* In conclusion, I am great at organizing a team and making things happen. In short, I would make an excellent team leader. Thank you.

TAYLOR: All righty, then. Let's put it to a vote! All y'all who want to vote for me, Taylor Rene Krystal Hawkins of the Lone Star State, raise your hands. Looks like I'm the winner. (Chapter 4) Teen Dream Misses! My daddy is a general, and I know what he'd say if he were here: (points to jungle) There might be more of us in there. We need to organize a search party. A Miss Teen Dream Recon Machine. (Chapter 2)

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NARRATOR: Two teams were organized and, after much debate, names were chosen: The Sparkle Ponies would stay on the beach, tend to the wounded, and try to salvage whatever they could from the wreckage. The Lost Girls would soldier into the jungle in the hopes of finding survivors. (Chapter 2)

The Lost Girls set off down the beach. Taylor led the way. Adina, Petra, Mary Lou and Tiara followed. The jungle gave way to a small clearing. Enormous totems rose next to the trees. With their angry mouths, jagged teeth, and blood-red, pupilless eyes, they were clearly meant to frighten.

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MARY LOU: Holy moly . . . You think there might be cannibals here? *(They hear something from the jungle)*

TAYLOR: Grab whatever you can. Follow my lead. *(Taylor holds up 3 fingers, counting down to 1)* Now! *(Girls launch sticks and rocks at the jungle. Hiss of pain from jungle)* Lost Girls, hold your fire.

NARRATOR: A willowy girl stepped out into the open, moaning. Her skin was the same deep brown as the carved figures.

TAYLOR: I'll try to communicate. *(Speaks slowly)* Hello! We need help. Is your village close?

NICOLE: My village is Denver. And I think it's a long way from here. I'm Nicole Ade. Miss Colorado.

TIARA: We have a Colorado where we're from, too! *(swivels hips, spreads arms wide, brings hands together prayer-style and bows)* Kipa aloha.

NICOLE: I speak *English*. I'm *American*. Did you learn those moves from Barbie's *Hawaiian Vacation* DVD?

TIARA: Ohmigosh, yes! Do your people have that, too?

TAYLOR: We're trying to find survivors. Did you see anybody else out here?

NICOLE: Just a lot of dead chaperones and camera crew. I'm glad to see you.

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MARY LOU: What do we do now?

TAYLOR: We should get back and let the others know. It's just us. We're the only survivors. We're on our own. (Chapter 3)

**********(Back on the beach)**********

TAYLOR: All right, Miss Teen Dreamers. Miss Montana? Is that the way a Miss Teen Dream sits, all slutty like that with her hoo-hoo showing?

MISS MONTANA: *(Knocks her knees together and yanks down the hem of her skirt)*

TAYLOR: Thank you. I've got a little bit of bad news: Everybody else is dead. *(Gasp from the crowd) (claps)* Teen Dreamers! We need to focus like it's the final interview round and the questions are all about anorexia and current events. Now, I know y'all are upset. This is just plain awful. But God doesn't make mistakes. Is this a setback, Teen Dreamers?

MISS NEW MEXICO: *(Points to tray in her forehead)* What about this?

PETRA: You know what would be cute on you? Bangs? So 1960s chic. You'd hardly notice the, um, the… addition.

MARY LOU: Love bangs!

PETRA: Miss Florida was the only one who had bangs and she's de – um, she's no longer participating in the pageant system. So you'd really stand out.

MISS NEW MEXICO: Stand out? Stand out! I *have a freaking tray stuck in my forehead!*

TAYLOR: Miss New Mexico, let's not get all down in the bummer basement where the creepy things live. There are people in heathen China who don't even have airline trays. WE have a lot to be grateful for. This is an opportunity for growth and the establishment of your personal brand. Everybody loves a survivor and a Miss Teen Dream contestant. When you put those two together, you have a lot of big endorsement opportunities when we get back. Let's find a place to camp and look for firewood. Tonight, we'll keep watch in shifts. (Chapter 4)

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NARRATOR: CLASSIFIED. ISLAND. 22:00 Hours . . . Sheltered by the dark, the agent watched the girls sleeping on the beach and shook his head. This was not good, not at all. *(Picks up phone and dials)*

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BOSS: This better be good.

AGENT: We've got a problem.

BOSS: Agent Jones, in six weeks, Operation Peacock is a go. Nothing can interfere. Nothing. A rescue mission to the island will mean attention. We don't want attention.

AGENT: I understand. What about the girls?

BOSS: Six weeks is a long time, Agent. And it's a hostile island. They'll be lucky to last two days. The official word is that there were no survivors. Operation Peacock goes on as scheduled. (Chapter 5)

SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

2015 National Qualifier
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